

masters or top-quality works by artists who are now enjoying their time in the sun. If the kitty is small, start with baby steps, collecting smaller works, or paperwork, or even only prints. A focus is helpful, binding, and makes you an expert in the eyes of the cognoscenti. Often, the low- to mid-rung investments may get you more bang for your buck over high investments in masters.

This brings us to point four: spending should be sustained over time, and you must hedge your bets, at least initially, by dispersing them across a range of artists, artworks, or art movements—just as you would with mutual funds.

Fifth, survey the market and work with a well-regarded art advisor or institutions such as galleries and even auction houses. These relationships will deliver; don't think they're making money off you as much as saving your money from costly mistakes.

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Finally, think of art as a mid- to long-term investment because quick turnarounds for profits can burn your fingers. A five-year window is okay; a 10-year window will gain you windfalls.

Collectors—even the knowledgeable ones—tend to react emotionally and are sometimes driven by their gut, but as an investor disallow the arrogance of your own beliefs to cloud your judgement. Collectors can live with their mistakes, but investors will rue them. The advantage collectors have, of course, is that they get to enjoy what they're spending on, while for investors all that matters is the sound of coins clinking their way to the piggy bank. So, why not be a bit of both? ■

Above: *The Fisherman* by Ganesh Pyne sold for around ₹49 crore, more than 15 times the low estimate at Christie's in London earlier this year